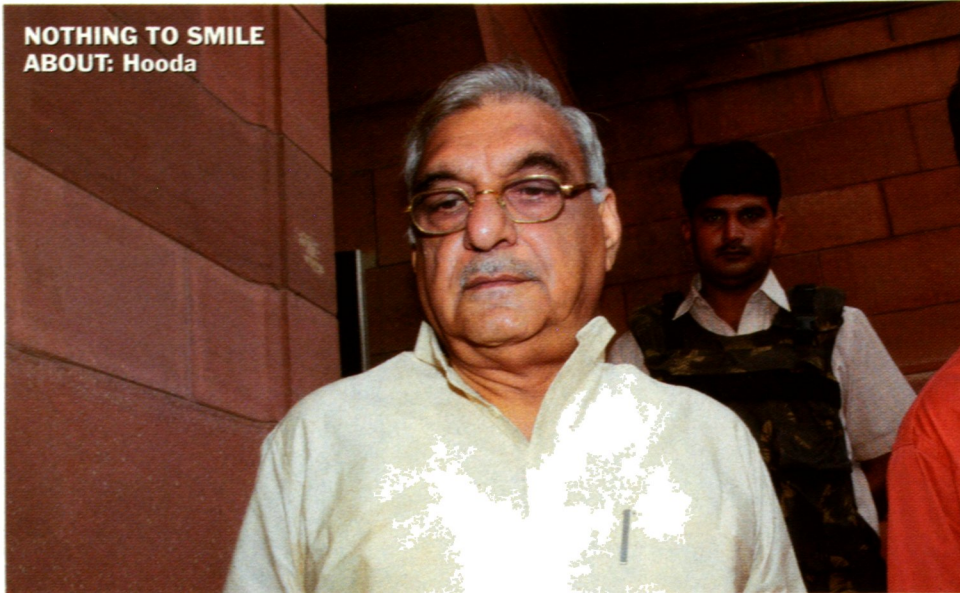


NOTHING TO SMILE ABOUT: Hooda



Hooda's Home Heat

CHANDIGARH Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda and his son, MP Deepender Hooda, are facing a mounting public ire on their home turf of Rohtak. Two months ago, the father-son duo were left red-faced when a

young woman from Rohtak committed suicide at the state police headquarters after alleging that she had been raped by some Haryana policemen. And now, the killing of a lady teacher in police action against the protest-

ing temporary teachers in the politically-sensitive town in the Jatland has sparked off a fresh wave of public anger and political outcry.

The demonstrators, mostly women, had gathered in Rohtak on September 7 to press for their demands for an increase in their wages and regularisation of their

services. When they insisted on presenting their memorandum to the chief minister or his son, the police used brutal force to disperse them. Raj Rani, a guest teacher from Jind, bled to death after being hit by bullets. The local administration promptly blamed the killing on firing by anti-social elements in the protesting crowd.

The post mortem, however, called the authorities' bluff by suggesting that the death was caused by plastic bullets fired from a close range. In a damage-limiting exercise, Hooda ordered a magisterial probe and granted a compensation of Rs 5 lakh to the kin of the deceased. But the incident has stoked public anger, and the opposition parties have jumped into the fray to milk the issue politically. Clearly, the Hoodas need to watch out on trouble brewing on their home front.

by Ramesh Vinayak

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The NSG meeting in Vienna had its after-effect on the high and mighty: due to time difference and a slew of multinational, intercontinental telephone calls, both Manmohan Singh and George Bush lost sleep for three straight days.

VOICES



"We opposed the deal and would continue to do so. Pranab Mukherjee has sold the country's sovereignty and rights."

D. Raja, CPI secretary

"Even if India and Pakistan decided to give Jammu and Kashmir independence, it would never really be free. Azadi or accession to Pakistan are not viable alternatives."

Omar Abdullah, National Conference president

"This nuclear waiver and the nuclear pact is going to help us to graduate from the nuclear security to nuclear independence"

A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, former president

"The US was interested in seeing the deal through because it would benefit its business houses manufacturing atomic power units, which has had no buyers in the past."

L.K. Advani, Leader of the Opposition

"Every time I look back, I think I did everything wrong in the past. So, I feel, it's better not to look back."

Shyam Benegal, filmmaker

